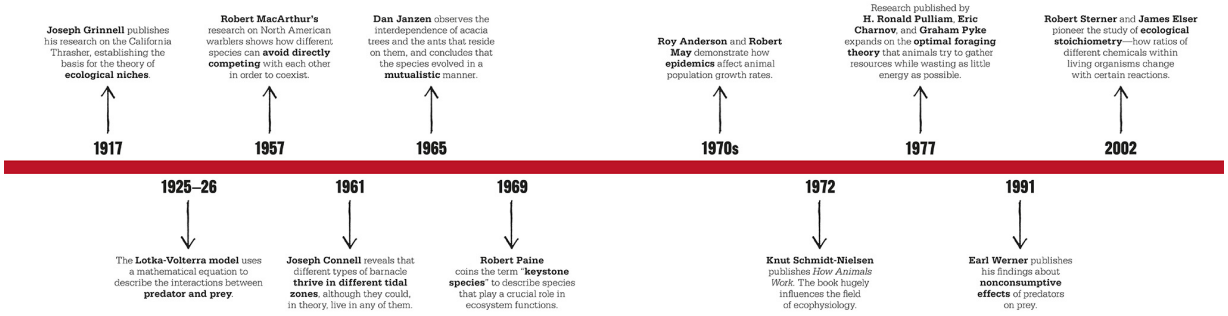
INTRODUCTION

In the 5th century BCE, the Greek historian Herodotus described watching crocodiles open their jaws for plovers to pick food from their teeth. He may have been the first to write about an ecological process—in this case a mutualistic relationship between reptiles and birds. Aristotle and Theophrastus observed many more interactions between animals and their environment in the 4th century BCE.

Over the next two millennia, countless other observations of the natural world were made, but a deep understanding of how organisms interacted with each other and the world around them was hampered by the inability to observe very small things, those that were active at night, or those living underwater. Additionally, few people with an interest in nature experienced much beyond their own local area. As technology improved and people began to travel the world, scientists such as Robert Hooke, Antonie van Leeuwenhoek, Carl Linnaeus, Alexander von Humboldt, Alfred Russel Wallace, Charles Darwin, and Johannes Warming became increasingly aware of ecological processes and laid the foundations of the science of ecology, even if they didn't use that word.



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